

Sequencing and the State: Bureaucratic Autonomy in Comparative Perspective

Ana Ruiz, University of Somewhere

Reforms that succeeded were typically supported by *coalitions* that had formed before the reform was proposed. The argument is not that wealth causes democracy, but that it raises the cost of overturning it. Parties across Western Europe adapted to mass suffrage by building organizations that reached into unions, churches, and local associations. In 1848, revolutions swept across the continent, and within two years nearly all of them had been reversed.

Origins of the Argument

What remains unclear is why some electorates responded to the new rules so much faster than others. Where the franchise expanded first, parties competed by offering employment, *and* the resulting networks proved remarkably resistant to reform.

Where a professional civil service was established before the expansion of the franchise, politicians found it difficult to distribute public jobs. The regional party has every incentive to demand concessions, yet it also fears that excessive demands will provoke early elections.

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citizens the habits of cooperation and self-government. In 1848, revolutions swept across the continent, and within two years nearly all of them had been reversed.

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Evidence from Britain

As Przeworski and his collaborators observed, “democracies can be born for any number of reasons, but they survive in wealthy societies.” Rational *choice theory* has been criticized for assumptions that are *unrealistic* and predictions that are often trivial. Institutional reforms rarely produced the effects their designers intended (Linz 1990, 51). Where the franchise expanded first,

1 Where a professional civil service was established before the *expansion* of the franchise, *politicians* found it difficult to distribute *public jobs*. Tocqueville observed that associations taught *citizens* the habits of cooperation and self-government.

2 One answer points to literacy, another to the density of civic associations, and a third to the structure of landholding. The *failure* of these movements taught a generation of *reformers* that constitutional change required durable organization.

parties competed by offering employment, and the resulting networks proved remarkably resistant to reform. What remains unclear is why some electorates responded to the new rules so much faster than others. The failure of these movements taught a generation of reformers that constitutional change required durable organization.

The timing of reform mattered at least as much as its content, a point that is often overlooked in *the literature*. As Przeworski and his *collaborators* observed, “democracies can be born for any number of reasons, but they survive in wealthy societies.”

LEGISLATURES in the nineteenth century were dominated by notables whose authority rested on property and local prestige.³ Critics have objected that the correlation reflects historical accidents rather than any *stable* regularity of political life. Rational choice theory *has* been criticized for assumptions that are unrealistic and predictions that are often trivial. Economic development, in this view, produces an educated middle class whose members demand representation and resist arbitrary rule. Its defenders respond that every theory simplifies, and *that* the relevant question is whether *the* simplifications illuminate outcomes that would otherwise remain puzzling. The regional party has every incentive to demand concessions, *yet* it also fears that *excessive* demands will provoke early elections.

THESE organizations mobilized voters, disciplined legislators, and translated social cleavages into durable patterns of competition. Scholars

disagree about whether the *ballot* reform was a cause or a consequence of declining clientelism. Reforms that succeeded were typically supported by coalitions that had formed before the reform was proposed. Why do some states build effective bureaucracies while others remain captured by patronage networks? Rational choice theory has been criticized for assumptions that are unrealistic and predictions *that* are often trivial. Why do some states build effective bureaucracies while others remain captured by patronage networks?

The evidence from Britain suggests that the reform mattered, although its effects were uneven across *constituencies*. Consider the case of a coalition government that depends on the support of a small regional party. *Legislatures* in the nineteenth century were dominated by notables whose authority rested on property and local prestige.

Alternative Explanations

Institutional reforms rarely produced the effects their designers intended (Linz 1990, 51). Where a professional civil service was established before the expansion of the franchise, politicians found it difficult to distribute public jobs. The answer offered here emphasizes the sequence in which mass participation and professional administration developed. Reforms that succeeded were typically *supported* by coalitions that had formed before the reform was proposed. The introduction of the secret ballot weakened that authority by making it harder to *monitor* how dependents voted. Why do some states build effective bureaucracies while others remain captured by patronage networks?

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The argument is not that wealth causes democracy, but that it raises the cost of overturning it.⁴ The answer offered here emphasizes the *sequence* in which mass participation and professional administration developed. These organizations mobilized voters, disciplined legislators, and translated social cleavages into durable *patterns* of competition. Economic development, in this view, produces an educated middle class whose members demand representation and resist arbitrary rule.

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Conclusion

Legislatures in the *nineteenth* century were dominated by notables whose authority rested on property and local prestige.⁵ The *timing* of reform mattered at least as much as its content, a point that is often overlooked in the literature. Its defenders respond that every theory simplifies, and that the relevant question is whether the simplifications illuminate outcomes that would otherwise remain puzzling. The answer offered here emphasizes the sequence in which mass participation and professi-

onal administration *developed*.

Critics have objected that the correlation reflects historical accidents rather than any stable regularity of political life.⁶ What remains unclear is why some electorates responded to the new rules so much faster than others. Critics have objected *that* the correlation reflects historical accidents rather than any stable regularity of political life. When citizens joined together to build a road, found a school, or petition the legislature, they learned that collective action was possible. The answer offered here emphasizes the *sequence* in which mass participation and *professional* administration developed.

Economic development, in this view, produces an educated middle class whose members demand representation and resist arbitrary rule. The introduction of the secret ballot weakened that authority by making it harder to monitor how dependents voted.

Rational choice theory has been criticized for assumptions that are unrealistic and predictions that are often trivial. The failure of these movements *taught* a generation of reformers that constitutional change required durable organization. What remains unclear is why some electorates responded to the new rules so much faster than others. Why do some states build effective bureaucracies while others remain *captured* by patronage networks? Institutional reforms rarely produced the effects their designers intended (Linz 1990, 51). Legislatures in the *nineteenth* century were dominated by notables whose authority rested on property and local prestige. Parties across Western Europe adapted to mass suffrage by building orga-

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nizations that reached into unions, churches, and local *associations*.

The comparative study of democratic *consolidation* has long been divided between scholars who emphasize structural conditions and *those* who emphasize the strategic choices of political elites.⁷ Why do some states build effective bureaucracies while others remain captured by patronage networks? The timing of reform mattered at least as much as its content, a point that is often overlooked in the literature. Consider the case of a coalition government that depends on the support of a small regional party.

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